

01

The Spanish from First Principles

Why Bb5 matters, why e5 survives, and how pressure becomes a long-term initiative.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will understand the Ruy Lopez as a struggle over e5, development, and useful tension rather than a bishop attack that wins a pawn.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate candidates for the side to move, identify the opponent's strongest resource, and choose the resulting structure you can explain. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 001 | PAGE 4

Decode: Why 3.Bb5 is indirect pressure

Bb5 pressures the defender so White can build the center; it does not simply win e5.

LESSON 002 | PAGE 8

Play: Why 3.Bb5 is indirect pressure

Bb5 pressures the defender so White can build the center; it does not simply win e5.

LESSON 003 | PAGE 12

Decode: The value of the e5 strongpoint

A strongpoint is useful when it supports activity, not when every piece is chained to it.

LESSON 004 | PAGE 16

Play: The value of the e5 strongpoint

A strongpoint is useful when it supports activity, not when every piece is chained to it.

LESSON 005 | PAGE 20

Decode: Useful tension versus premature exchange

Keep tension when the opponent must keep solving it.

LESSON 006 | PAGE 24

Play: Useful tension versus premature exchange

Keep tension when the opponent must keep solving it.

VOLUME OBJECTIVE

You will understand the Ruy Lopez as a struggle over e5, development, and useful tension rather than a bishop attack that wins a pawn.

DECODE PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Decode: Why 3.Bb5 is indirect pressure



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Bb5 pins the defender of e5 only in a strategic sense: Bxc6 can remove it, but Black may recapture and still protect the pawn tactically.

DECISION RULE

Does Bxc6 actually win e5 after every recapture and tactic, or is maintaining tension more valuable?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Black develops, questions the bishop, and preserves the e5 center without making unnecessary concessions.

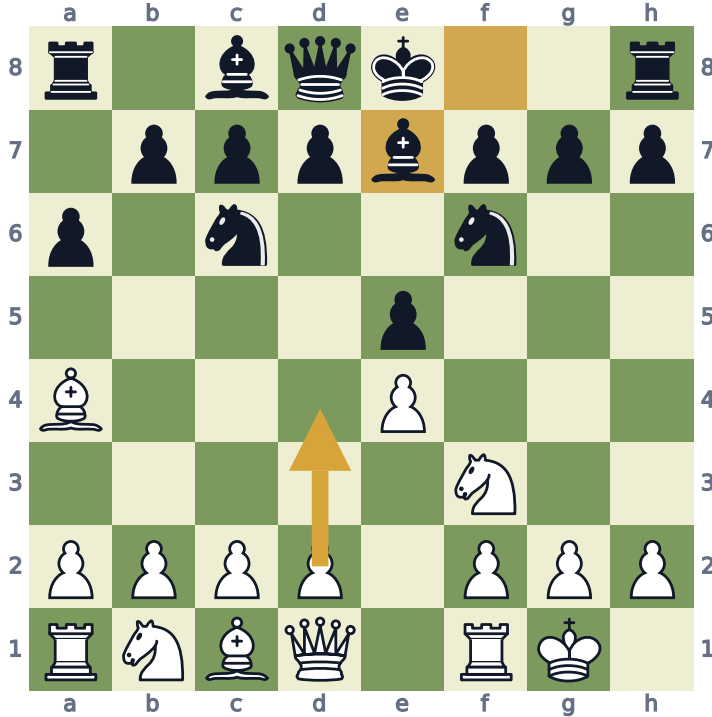
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White increases pressure with Re1 and c3-d4, turning the bishop's presence into central leverage.

MEMORY RULE | Bb5 pressures the defender so White can build the center; it does not simply win e5.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Bb5 pins the defender of e5 only in a strategic sense: Bxc6 can remove it, but Black may recapture and still protect the pawn tactically.

BLACK'S PLAN

Black develops, questions the bishop, and preserves the e5 center without making unnecessary concessions.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White increases pressure with Re1 and c3-d4, turning the bishop's presence into central leverage.

FAILURE MODE

Counting attackers and defenders without calculating the zwischenzug or changed pawn structure.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Does Bxc6 actually win e5 after every recapture and tactic, or is maintaining tension more valuable? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

RULE | Bb5 pressures the defender so White can build the center; it does not simply win e5.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7



- Nf3: White reroutes a knight to f3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Bb5: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- a6: Black questions the b5 bishop and asks White to choose tension or structural damage.
- Ba4: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Bb5 pins the defender of e5 only in a strategic sense: Bxc6 can remove it, but Black may recapture and still protect the pawn tactically.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Does Bxc6 actually win e5 after every recapture and tactic, or is maintaining tension more valuable? White's resource is: White increases pressure with Re1 and c3-d4, turning the bishop's presence into central leverage. The line fails as a template when: Counting attackers and defenders without calculating the zwischenzug or changed pawn structure.

STORE THIS | Bb5 pressures the defender so White can build the center; it does not simply win e5.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

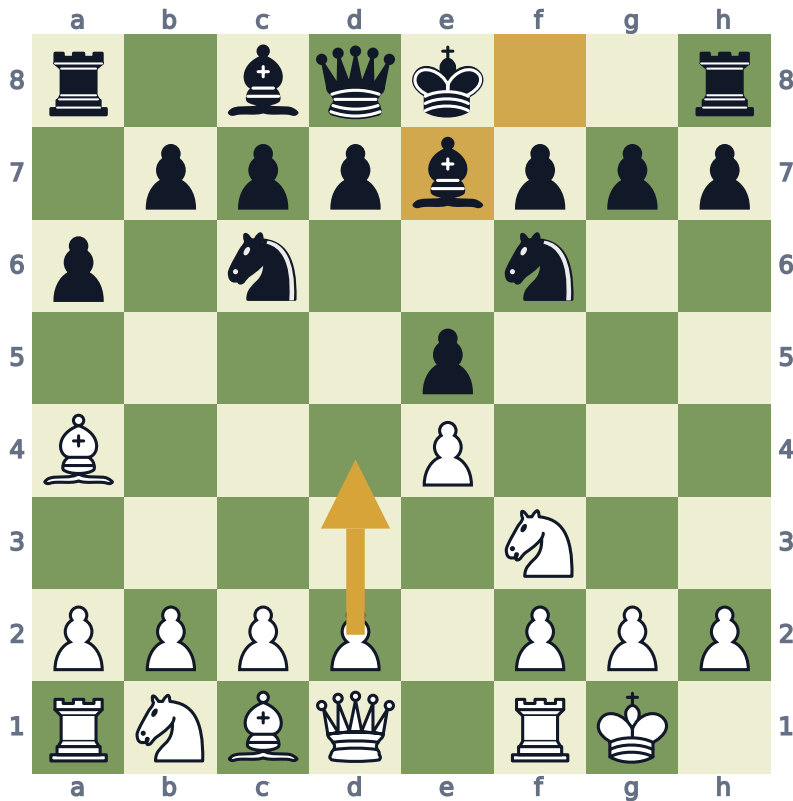
1. Bb5 pins the defender of e5 only in a strategic sense: Bxc6 can remove it, but Black may recapture and still protect the pawn tactically. 2. Black develops, questions the bishop, and preserves the e5 center without making unnecessary concessions. 3. White increases pressure with Re1 and c3-d4, turning the bishop's presence into central leverage. 4. Does Bxc6 actually win e5 after every recapture and tactic, or is maintaining tension more valuable? 5. Counting attackers and defenders without calculating the zwischenzug or changed pawn structure.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 8 plies from memory, then replay: 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Why 3.Bb5 is indirect pressure



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Bb5 pins the defender of e5 only in a strategic sense: Bxc6 can remove it, but Black may recapture and still protect the pawn tactically.

DECISION RULE

Does Bxc6 actually win e5 after every recapture and tactic, or is maintaining tension more valuable?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

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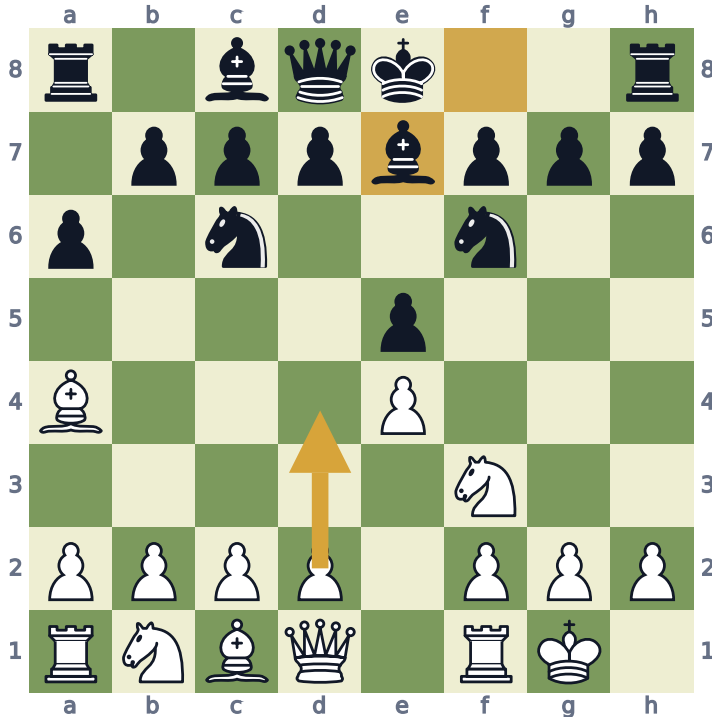
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White increases pressure with Re1 and c3-d4, turning the bishop's presence into central leverage.

MEMORY RULE | Bb5 pressures the defender so White can build the center; it does not simply win e5.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK'S PLAN

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

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WHITE'S PLAN

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FAILURE MODE

Counting attackers and defenders without calculating the zwischenzug or changed pawn structure.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Does Bxc6 actually win e5 after every recapture and tactic, or is maintaining tension more valuable? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

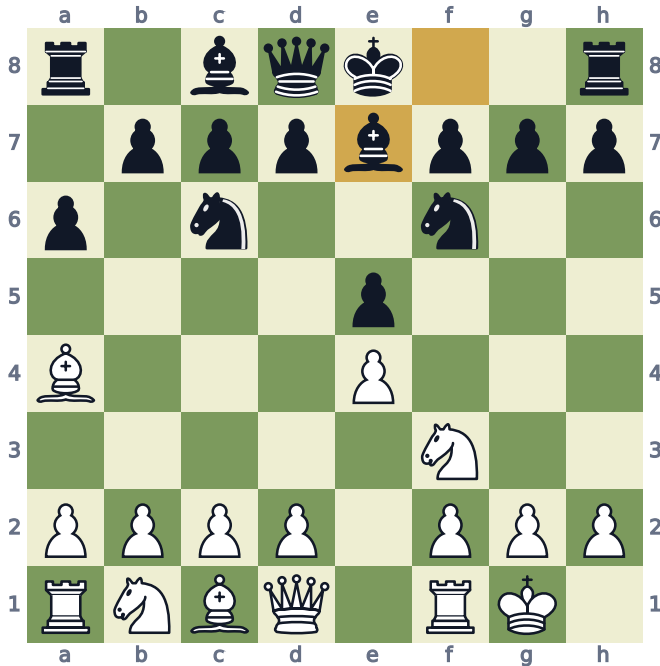
RULE | Bb5 pressures the defender so White can build the center; it does not simply win e5.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7



- Bb5: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- a6: Black questions the b5 bishop and asks White to choose tension or structural damage.
- Ba4: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

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WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

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STORE THIS | Bb5 pressures the defender so White can build the center; it does not simply win e5.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

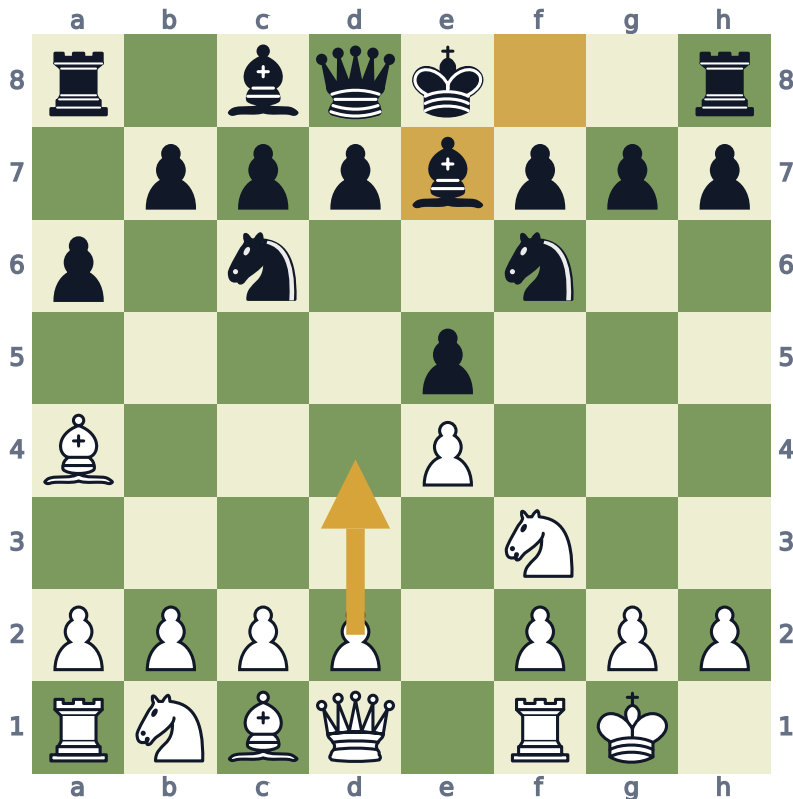
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 10 plies from memory, then replay: 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The value of the e5 strongpoint



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black's e5 pawn claims central space and restricts White, but it needs support; White's whole setup asks how to increase pressure without releasing tension.

DECISION RULE

Which piece is doing a real job in the defense of e5, and can White distract or exchange it?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Reinforce e5, castle, and prepare counterplay that makes White spend time away from d4.

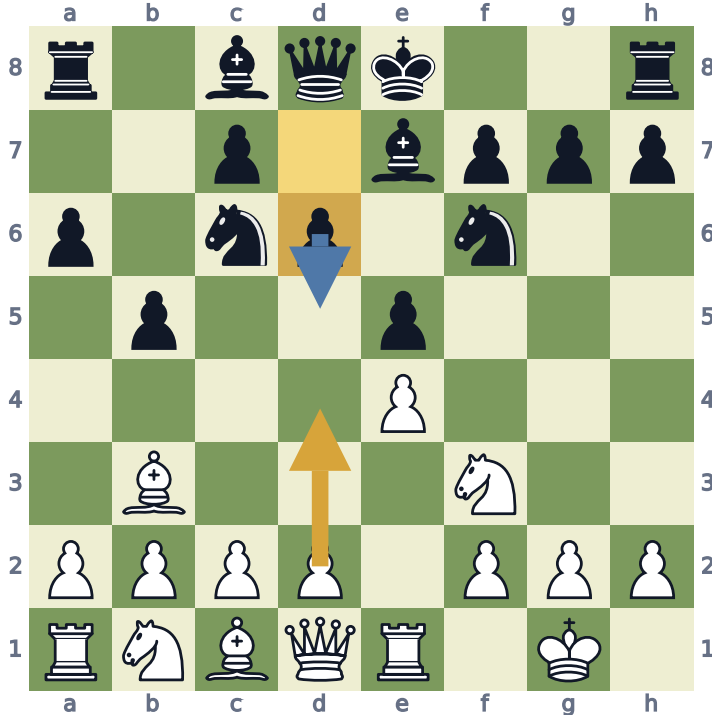
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White plays c3 and d4, sometimes h3 first, to challenge the pawn under ideal conditions.

MEMORY RULE | A strongpoint is useful when it supports activity, not when every piece is chained to it.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Black's e5 pawn claims central space and restricts White, but it needs support; White's whole setup asks how to increase pressure without releasing tension.

BLACK'S PLAN

Reinforce e5, castle, and prepare counterplay that makes White spend time away from d4.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White plays c3 and d4, sometimes h3 first, to challenge the pawn under ideal conditions.

FAILURE MODE

Defending e5 with passive pieces until Black has no counterplay.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which piece is doing a real job in the defense of e5, and can White distract or exchange it? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

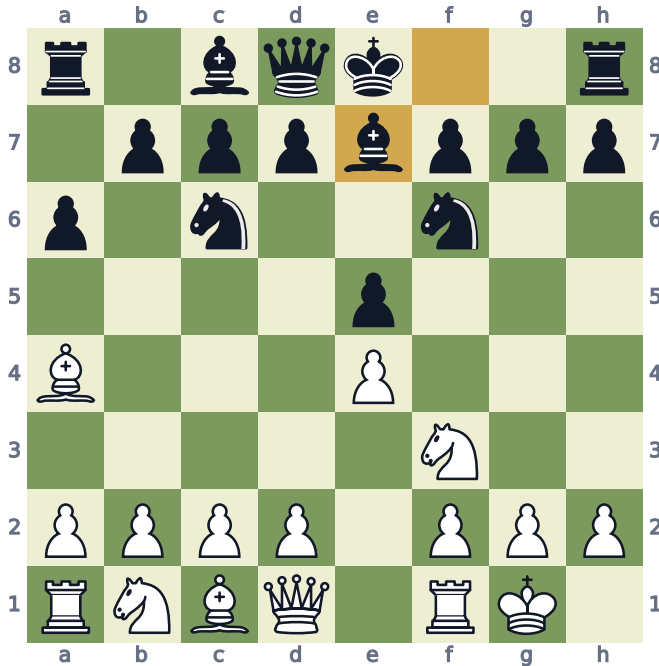
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6



- Bb5: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- a6: Black questions the b5 bishop and asks White to choose tension or structural damage.
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WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black's e5 pawn claims central space and restricts White, but it needs support; White's whole setup asks how to increase pressure without releasing tension.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which piece is doing a real job in the defense of e5, and can White distract or exchange it? White's resource is: White plays c3 and d4, sometimes h3 first, to challenge the pawn under ideal conditions. The line fails as a template when: Defending e5 with passive pieces until Black has no counterplay.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

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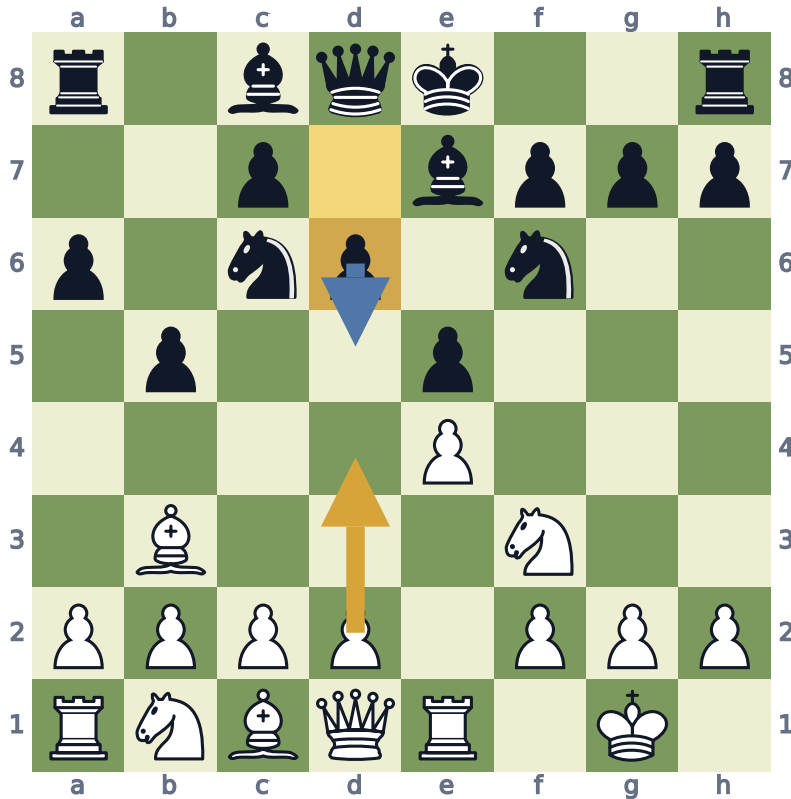
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 10 plies from memory, then replay: 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The value of the e5 strongpoint



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black's e5 pawn claims central space and restricts White, but it needs support; White's whole setup asks how to increase pressure without releasing tension.

DECISION RULE

Which piece is doing a real job in the defense of e5, and can White distract or exchange it?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Reinforce e5, castle, and prepare counterplay that makes White spend time away from d4.

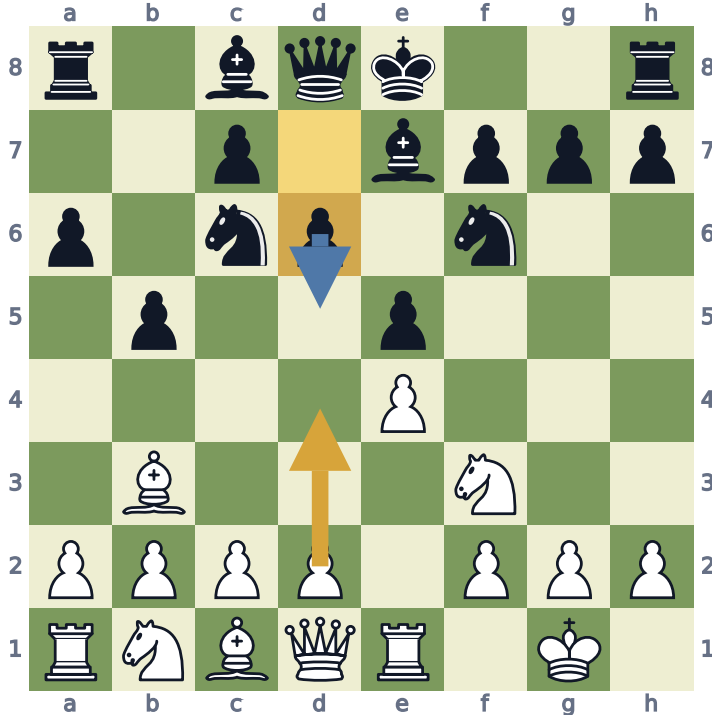
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK'S PLAN

Reinforce e5, castle, and prepare counterplay that makes White spend time away from d4.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

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FAILURE MODE

Defending e5 with passive pieces until Black has no counterplay.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which piece is doing a real job in the defense of e5, and can White distract or exchange it? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

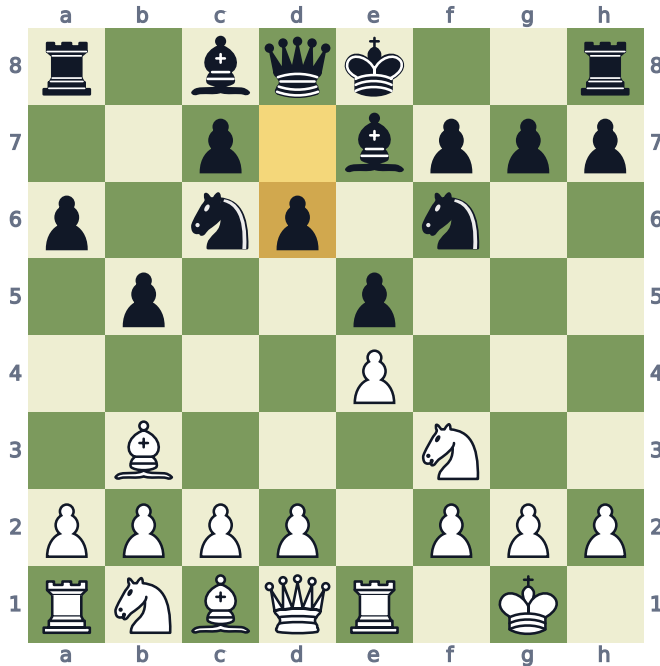
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6



- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Re1: White places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.
- b5: Black gains bishop tempo and queenside space while creating a possible pawn target.
- Bb3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black's e5 pawn claims central space and restricts White, but it needs support; White's whole setup asks how to increase pressure without releasing tension.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which piece is doing a real job in the defense of e5, and can White distract or exchange it? White's resource is: White plays c3 and d4, sometimes h3 first, to challenge the pawn under ideal conditions. The line fails as a template when: Defending e5 with passive pieces until Black has no counterplay.

STORE THIS | A strongpoint is useful when it supports activity, not when every piece is chained to it.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

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4. What exact question decides the next move?

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ANSWER KEY

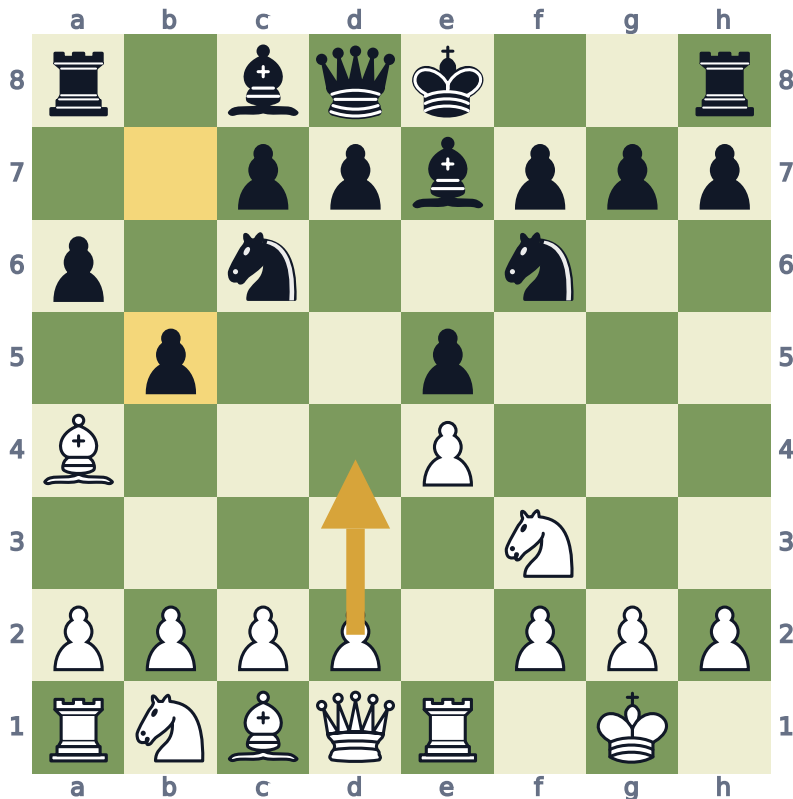
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Useful tension versus premature exchange



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

The Spanish position stores energy in unresolved choices: Bxc6, d4, ...b5, and ...d5. Timing determines who benefits from the release.

DECISION RULE

If the tension is released now, which side gains a tempo, file, or favorable recapture?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Black keeps the center stable and creates queenside space while preparing a freeing break.

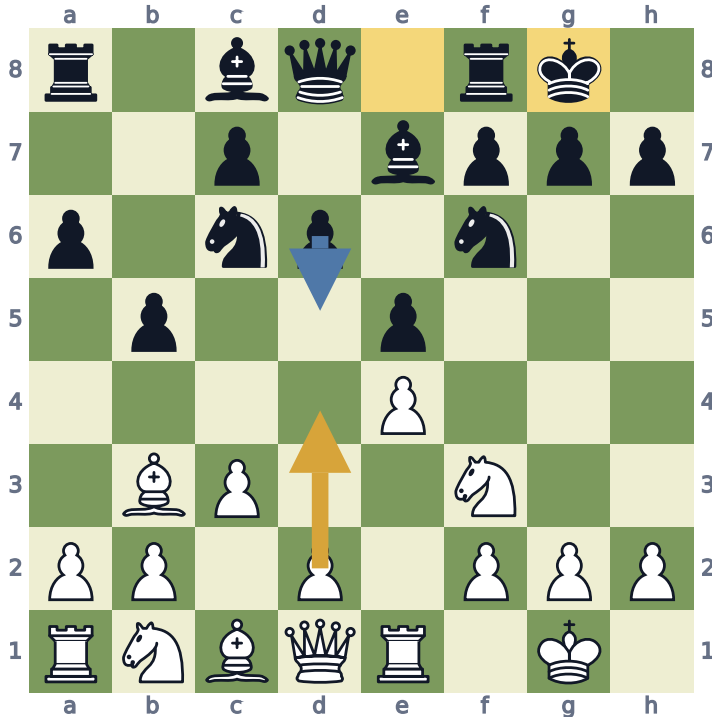
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White keeps the bishop, supports d4, and waits until an exchange improves piece placement or pawn structure.

MEMORY RULE | Keep tension when the opponent must keep solving it.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

The Spanish position stores energy in unresolved choices: Bxc6, d4, ...b5, and ...d5. Timing determines who benefits from the release.

BLACK'S PLAN

Black keeps the center stable and creates queenside space while preparing a freeing break.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White keeps the bishop, supports d4, and waits until an exchange improves piece placement or pawn structure.

FAILURE MODE

Exchanging merely to simplify the position without identifying the improved piece or structure.

DECISION TEST

Ask: If the tension is released now, which side gains a tempo, file, or favorable recapture? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

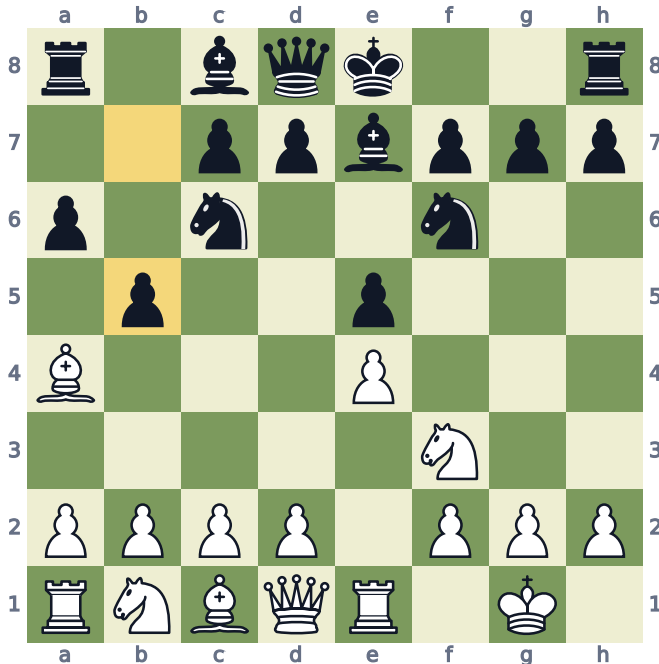
RULE | Keep tension when the opponent must keep solving it.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O



- Ba4: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
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If the tension is released now, which side gains a tempo, file, or favorable recapture? White's resource is: White keeps the bishop, supports d4, and waits until an exchange improves piece placement or pawn structure. The line fails as a template when: Exchanging merely to simplify the position without identifying the improved piece or structure.

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ANSWER KEY

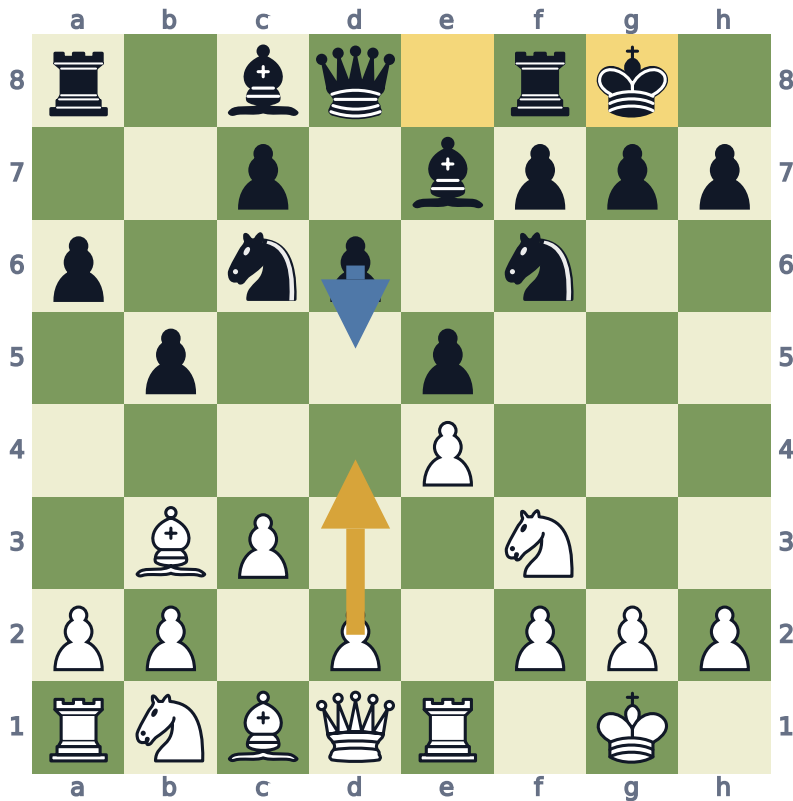
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Useful tension versus premature exchange



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

The Spanish position stores energy in unresolved choices: Bxc6, d4, ...b5, and ...d5. Timing determines who benefits from the release.

DECISION RULE

If the tension is released now, which side gains a tempo, file, or favorable recapture?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Black keeps the center stable and creates queenside space while preparing a freeing break.

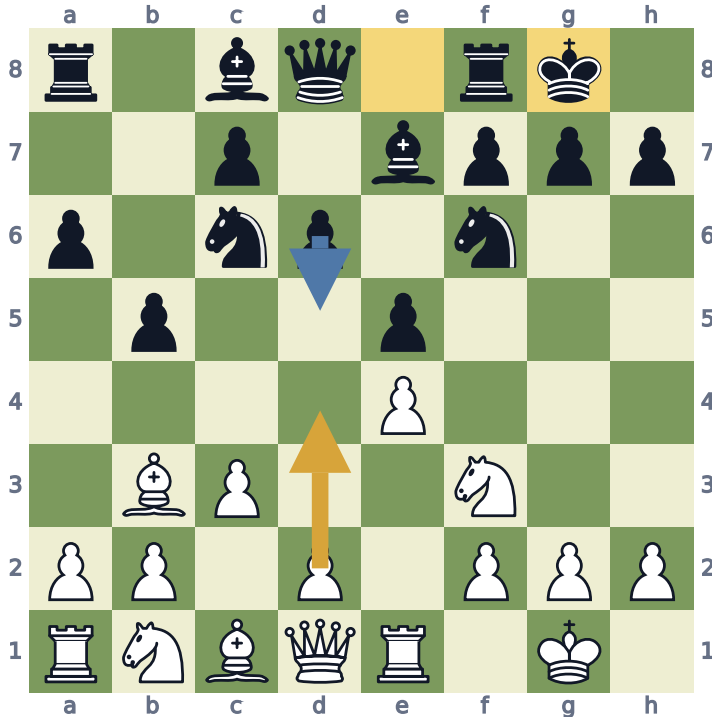
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

The Spanish position stores energy in unresolved choices: Bxc6, d4, ...b5, and ...d5. Timing determines who benefits from the release.

BLACK'S PLAN

Black keeps the center stable and creates queenside space while preparing a freeing break.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

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FAILURE MODE

Exchanging merely to simplify the position without identifying the improved piece or structure.

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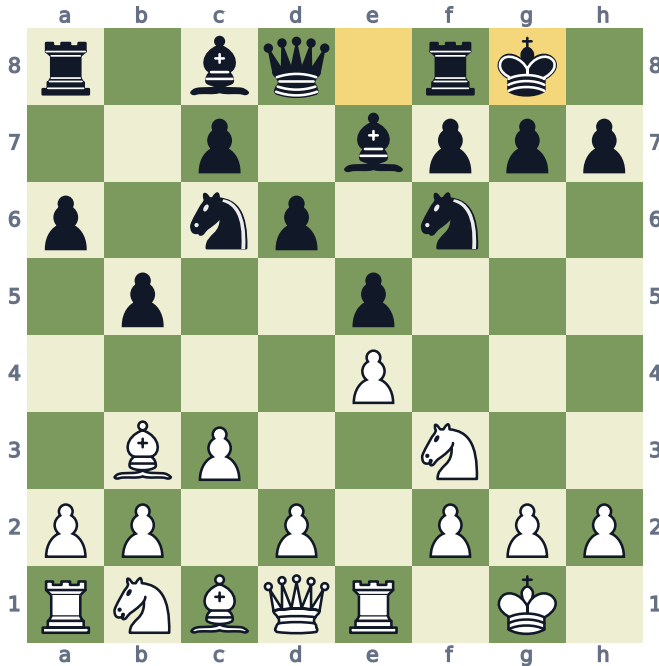
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- Bb3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- c3: White supports d4 and reserves c2 as a retreat square for the Spanish bishop.
- O-O: Black secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The Spanish position stores energy in unresolved choices: Bxc6, d4, ...b5, and ...d5. Timing determines who benefits from the release.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

If the tension is released now, which side gains a tempo, file, or favorable recapture? White's resource is: White keeps the bishop, supports d4, and waits until an exchange improves piece placement or pawn structure. The line fails as a template when: Exchanging merely to simplify the position without identifying the improved piece or structure.

STORE THIS | Keep tension when the opponent must keep solving it.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. The Spanish position stores energy in unresolved choices: Bxc6, d4, ...b5, and ...d5. Timing determines who benefits from the release. 2. Black keeps the center stable and creates queenside space while preparing a freeing break. 3. White keeps the bishop, supports d4, and waits until an exchange improves piece placement or pawn structure. 4. If the tension is released now, which side gains a tempo, file, or favorable recapture? 5. Exchanging merely to simplify the position without identifying the improved piece or structure.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 001 Decode: Why 3.Bb5 is indirect pressure

Prompt: Does Bxc6 actually win e5 after every recapture and tactic, or is maintaining tension more valuable?

Recall: Bb5 pressures the defender so White can build the center; it does not simply win e5.

LESSON 002 Play: Why 3.Bb5 is indirect pressure

Prompt: Does Bxc6 actually win e5 after every recapture and tactic, or is maintaining tension more valuable?

Recall: Bb5 pressures the defender so White can build the center; it does not simply win e5.

LESSON 003 Decode: The value of the e5 strongpoint

Prompt: Which piece is doing a real job in the defense of e5, and can White distract or exchange it?

Recall: A strongpoint is useful when it supports activity, not when every piece is chained to it.

LESSON 004 Play: The value of the e5 strongpoint

Prompt: Which piece is doing a real job in the defense of e5, and can White distract or exchange it?

Recall: A strongpoint is useful when it supports activity, not when every piece is chained to it.

LESSON 005 Decode: Useful tension versus premature exchange

Prompt: If the tension is released now, which side gains a tempo, file, or favorable recapture?

Recall: Keep tension when the opponent must keep solving it.

LESSON 006 Play: Useful tension versus premature exchange

Prompt: If the tension is released now, which side gains a tempo, file, or favorable recapture?

Recall: Keep tension when the opponent must keep solving it.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's plan, one candidate for the side to move, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

Why 3.Bb5 is indirect pressure

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7

Decision: Does Bxc6 actually win e5 after every recapture and tactic, or is maintaining tension more valuable?

Memory: Bb5 pressures the defender so White can build the center; it does not simply win e5.

CARD 2

The value of the e5 strongpoint

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6

Decision: Which piece is doing a real job in the defense of e5, and can White distract or exchange it?

Memory: A strongpoint is useful when it supports activity, not when every piece is chained to it.

CARD 3

Useful tension versus premature exchange

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O

Decision: If the tension is released now, which side gains a tempo, file, or favorable recapture?

Memory: Keep tension when the opponent must keep solving it.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
001 Decode: Why 3.Bb5 is indirect pressure	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
002 Play: Why 3.Bb5 is indirect pressure	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
003 Decode: The value of the e5 strongpoint	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
004 Play: The value of the e5 strongpoint	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
005 Decode: Useful tension versus premature exchange	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
006 Play: Useful tension versus premature exchange	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name both sides' strongest plans, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.